



YOU ARE **15 WEEKS 3 DAYS**

172 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

Now the toes are lengthening and a gentle arch to the foot is beginning to take shape. Your baby can grasp her feet at will but has difficulty bringing them up to her mouth: this is not a problem a little later in pregnancy.

“It’s time for another routine prenatal appointment to ensure everything is progressing well with you and your baby.”

You may have a prenatal appointment around 16 weeks, if you had your last appointment at around 12 weeks. You’ll be weighed, your urine tested, and your blood pressure measured, and the baby’s heart rate monitored. Furthermore, the doctor should be able to hear your [baby’s heartbeat](#), which can be very reassuring.

Women who do not have the [nuchal translucency scan](#) at around 11–14 weeks of pregnancy, may be offered the [quadruple test](#), in the second trimester, which is a screening test for Down syndrome and other chromosomal abnormalities.

This appointment also offers you an opportunity to discuss any concerns you may have, and your doctor will report the results of the routine tests (see [Your first prenatal visit](#)) you had at your first prenatal appointment, or shortly thereafter.

If your blood test results show that your hemoglobin levels were low, your doctor may offer you a prescription for iron.

MATERNITY WEAR

Maternity wear first appeared around the middle of the 19th century. At this time a prudish society felt that pregnancy should be hidden. For this same reason, and for the well-being of mother and child, women were encouraged to stay in bed in the weeks leading up to the birth.

YOUR GROWING BUMP

You’ll need to choose clothes that accommodate your growing belly, but that doesn’t have to mean investing in a whole new maternity wardrobe just yet.

The following innovations will help keep you comfortable and extend the life of your normal clothes for a few weeks at least:

- **Pregnancy support pants:** these stretch with you and ease the strain on your lower back, while giving you a smoother outline.
- **Pants expander:** an elastic belt that enables you to wear your jeans with a burgeoning belly. Alternatively, loop a rubber band—or, for extra girth, a slice cut from a pair of tights—around